1.1 State and National Governments

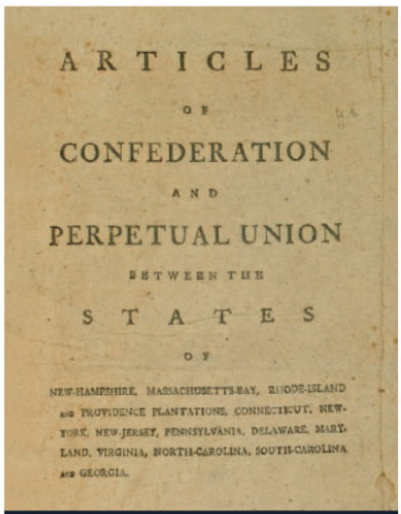
The last thing revolutionaries who have broken free from oppressive rulers want is the same way of governing. American revolutionaries wanted a new style of government—and one with limited power.

MAIN IDEA The Articles of Confederation limited the power of the new national government, while state governments retained much of their independence.

CREATING ORDER

Part of the legacy of the American struggle for independence included the establishment of a government based on republicanism, or the idea that government's power comes from its citizens and their representatives. Even as the war raged, each state moved forward and set up its own government.

Elected representatives from each state met and drafted a **constitution**, or a plan for government. Many state constitutions included lists of rights to which every citizen was entitled, such as the freedom to practice any religion. Once the constitutions were drafted and revised, the state representatives **ratified**, or approved, them.


ARTICLES
OF
CONFEDERATION
AND
PERPETUAL UNION
BETWEEN THE
STATES
OF
NEW-HAMPSHIRE, MASSACHUSETTS-BAY, RHODE-ISLAND AND PROVIDENCE PLANTATIONS, CONNECTICUT, NEW-YORK, NEW-JERSEY, PENNSYLVANIA, DELAWARE, MARYLAND, VIRGINIA, NORTH-CAROLINA, SOUTH-CAROLINA AND GEORGIA.

The Articles of Confederation went through six drafts between 1775 and 1777 before Congress finally approved it and then submitted it to the 13 states for ratification.

Many states decided to organize their governments with governors and two-house legislatures elected by the people. Organizing legislatures into two parts, instead of one, ensured that lawmakers would have to share power and limited the power of governors. Some states, such as Pennsylvania, opted for no governor at all.

State constitutions were a new concept at the time. Most western European countries did not grant such power to elected legislatures. The process of writing and ratifying state constitutions served as a model for the new national government to introduce future political institutions and ideas. One of the new ideas that emerged was a constitution that would govern all American states.

A NATIONAL PLAN

After the states ratified their constitutions, they decided to band together to defeat the British. Representatives from many of the states started meeting regularly to draft a plan for unification called the Articles of Confederation.

The Articles of Confederation gave Congress the ability to make decisions about the military. They also outlined a national plan of **sovereign**, or self-governing, states. The **federal**, or national, government would have little power of its own, nor would it include a president or a federal court system. It would simply serve as an administrator to help unify the states. This limited federal government reflected the ideals first put forth in the Declaration of Independence, which stated that a government should derive its powers "from the consent of the governed."

The Articles of Confederation assigned foreign affairs and relations with Native Americans, the ability to declare war and peace, and the postal

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.

AMERICAN PLACES

Maryland State House, Annapolis

Did you know that the nation's capital wasn't always Washington, D.C.? The Maryland State House is the only state capitol building that has also served as the nation's capital. It is located in Annapolis, Maryland, a city often referred to as the "Athens of America" because of its rich cultural and political history and coastal location.

Between November 1783 and August 1784, the Continental Congress met at the Maryland State House. In the Old Senate Chamber, the Congress accepted Washington's resignation as commander in chief of the Continental Army. It also ratified the Treaty of Paris. Both events signaled the end of the American Revolution.



service to Congress. The national government could produce money but not levy taxes. If it needed money, it had to ask the states for funds. Congress needed to approve any legislation that would affect the country.

Americans liked these ideas because they addressed liberties denied to them under British rule. They also laid the foundation for **constitutionalism**, an approach to government that strictly defines and limits its powers. In March 1781, all 13 states finally ratified the Articles of Confederation, which would serve as the first constitution of the United States for eight years.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What responsibilities did the national government have under the Articles of Confederation?
2. **ANALYZE CAUSE AND EFFECT** How did the development of state constitutions influence the national plan for government?
3. **IDENTIFY MAIN IDEAS AND DETAILS** How were the ideals put forth in the Declaration of Independence reflected in the new American government?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.